

PTI

NET CATCH Chaitanya Baghel being taken to court in Raipur, Jul. 18

Takeaways

- **The ED arrests Chaitanya Baghel for excise evasion charges**
- **This could affect his father ex-CM Bhupesh Baghel's standing in the INC**

how, on his own birthday in August 2023, the ED had raided his OSDs. "The kind of birthday gifts Modi-Shah give cannot be given by anyone in any democracy. Thank you... I will remember them for life," he wrote. A non-birthday present too had come in March, when the CBI raided his premises in the Mahadev app scam.

Baghel was also heard lamenting how Pappu Bansal, an accused said to be close to him, could be seen breezing in and out of the ED office. That's not a bad reading of the ED's self-revealed strategy: to get those close to the 'big fish' to sing. Sources claim it was Bansal who explained the "financial trail" leading to Chaitanya. Pappu Dhillon, a Chaitanya aide now in jail, may play a like role too. K.K. Shrivastava, a "tantric/astrologer" close to Baghel, was arrested from Bhopal on unrelated complaints—also apparently meant to persuade him to read the future well and cooperate.

BIG TREES DON'T FALL

Baghel has been vocal about tree-felling in an Adani coal project in a Raigarh forest. Chaitanya's arrest, he claims, is meant to deflect focus from that. The BJP denies any link. Anyway, Baghel's standing in his party won't stay unaffected. A section still prefers him: Priyanka Gandhi, for one, tweeted in his support. But a dichotomy is visible too: Baghel-baiter Charandas Mahant has been made leader of opposition.

The former CM is a leader who even the BJP acknowledges as its most popular rival in the state. To retain that centrality, Baghel has a fight on his hands. ■

▶ ODISHA

SHOCK AND AFTERSHOCK

The state stays ablaze in the headlines with another girl victim. The rituals of anger and blame-giving repeat on loop

Despite her critical condition, she told them three men had abducted her on motorbikes, taken her to the Bhargavi river bank, poured kerosene over her, and set her on fire. First taken to a community health centre, then shifted to AIIMS Bhubaneswar, on July 20 the Odisha government opted to airlift her to AIIMS, New Delhi. She had suffered nearly 70-75 per cent burns.

Police investigations confirmed the sequence of events, as related by the girl in a statement. A school dropout, she was visiting her uncle on the day of the incident. Eight people—including some of her relatives—have now been detained for questioning.

The attack has set off an intensified phase of political unrest, in tandem with public anger. In Puri, demonstrations broke out outside Balanga police station, and later outside AIIMS Bhubaneswar's burns unit, forcing police to disperse the crowds. It was almost as if public protests over gender violence in Odisha had carried over without a break from the Fakir Mohan College self-immolation case, only getting angrier.

Former CM and BJD leader Naveen Patnaik, too, did a replay, issuing his second successive broadside at the BJP regime on his social media handle within a week. "Such unthinkable incidents against women are now being reported almost daily across #Odisha.... It shows that criminals have become emboldened under the present government and are not worried about being punished," he wrote.

Takeaways

- **A 15-year-old girl abducted and set ablaze near Puri**
- **Public protests, political critiques continue unbroken**
- **Majhi govt still hurt after Balasore**

ON THE DEFENSIVE

Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi said the government would ensure the best treatment for the victim and promised strict action against the culprits. Deputy CM Pravati Parida also visited her at AIIMS, New Delhi.

But public opinion is being moulded by the fact that this has come in the slipstream of Balasore, especially the fact that its 20-year-old victim had set herself aflame to protest institutional apathy as much as sexual harassment. ■